

■ By Shyam Lal Yadav

In the third week of May at a function to release the 'Report to the People 2008' on the UPA Government's completion of the fourth year in office, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh waxed eloquent about the achievements of his regime while laying special emphasis on its record in open government. "The UPA Government has set a new standard for accountability and transparency in governance," he announced. The prime minister was only partially right since it was the UPA Government that had enacted the Right to Information (RTI) Act, which gave ordinary citizens the right to seek both information and accountability from their leaders. However, it is the actual implementation of open governance that remains a closely-guarded secret.

On November 6, 2007, INDIA TODAY invoked the RTI, seeking information from the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) whether Union ministers had filed details of their assets and liabilities. This followed reports that the prime minister was miffed after his ministers repeatedly ignored reminders from the Cabinet Secretariat to file these details. The ministers who showed utter disdain for the cabinet secretary's reminders were from the Congress as well as from its alliance partners.

The practice of asking all Union ministers to file details of assets and tax returns with the PMO every year was initiated by Atal Bihari Vajpayee after he took over as prime minister in 1999. Though the move met with initial resistance, especially from the BJP's alliance partners, eventually most ministers fell in line. A system was also put in place to ensure that the process was adhered to. On taking the oath of office, every minister is handed a copy of the code of conduct. It says, among other things, that ministers should disclose to the PMO details of their assets, liabilities and business interests along with those of their family members. Manmohan, in the best interests of transparency, kept up the tradition.

This magazine's efforts to gather information of the ministers' assets,

NARENDRA BISHT



## OPEN SECRET

liabilities and tax returns made it amply evident that most of the UPA ministers have scant regard for the prime minister's lofty ideals. Our RTI application, sent to both the PMO and the Cabinet Secretariat, asked these specific questions: "Whether the prime minister has asked his cabinet/state ministers to file the details of their assets and liabilities annually; the exact date of such advice; reminders sent to the defaulters and the names of ministers who expressed their inability to file such details."

That is when we discovered that the openness which Manmohan talked about is mostly a farce and the bureaucrats and politicians were doing what

**ABOVE SCRUTINY: Manmohan Singh (right) with senior colleagues**

they were best at—passing the buck. On November 19, 2007, 10 days after the RTI application was filed, the PMO responded saying that the "Cabinet Secretariat dealt with the matter and you are advised to contact the Central public information officer, Cabinet Secretariat, for further information in the matter." Shockingly enough, a week later, the secretariat responded to the initial application stating that the "information asked for pertains to the Prime Minister's Office and the Cabinet Secretariat is not directly concerned with the subject matter. This secretariat... has transferred your request to the Prime Minister's Office, South Block... for appropriate action."

**Under the RTI Act it is mandatory to reply to all queries within four weeks, but most go unanswered for months.**